

Voter polarisation and party responsiveness: Why parties emphasise divided issues, but remain silent on unified issues

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Abstract. How does voter polarisation affect party responsiveness? Previous research has shown that political parties emphasise political issues that are important to their voters. However, it is posited in this article that political parties are not equally responsive to citizen demands across all issue areas. The hypothesis is that party responsiveness varies considerably with the preference configuration of the electorate. More specifically, it is argued that party responsiveness increases with the polarisation of issues among voters. To test these theoretical expectations, party responsiveness is analysed across nine West European countries from 1982 until 2013. Data on voter attention and voter preferences with regard to specific policy issues from a variety of national election studies is combined with Comparative Manifestos Project data on parties' emphasis of these issues in their election manifestos. The findings have major implications for understanding party competition and political representation in Europe.

Keywords: polarisation; party responsiveness; issue attention; manifestos

Introduction

Polarisation is often negatively associated with democratic politics. If one of the central functions of political parties is to aggregate and articulate citizens' preferences and to translate them into governmental policy, then it would seem that when the electorate is divided, there would be a breakdown of democratic politics as parties cannot achieve a balanced representation of citizens' interests. Indeed, both Lijphart (1999) and Powell (1982) have argued that extremely polarised party systems experience higher levels of political conflict and citizen protest. The alternative view is that division can help invigorate politics. When parties or voters are divided over an issue, voters are more motivated to participate to ensure that their policy preference wins and parties are compelled to provide the engaged voters with a clear alternative. Indeed, Dalton (2011: 120) argues that 'in order for voters to make clear policy choices, they must have clear options among the available parties'.

At the same time, while voters have identifiable choices when parties are divided on an issue (Carmines & Stimson 1989), political parties also have a clearer sense of the issue priorities of their electorate when voter preferences diverge. The relationship between strong partisanship and a decline in split-ticket voting in the United States highlights this (Hetherington 2001; Jacobson 2005; Abramowitz 2010). When voters have stronger preferences, they are more likely to concentrate their votes on one single party on the ballot. Therefore, parties are more likely to respond to voters' issue priorities when there is disagreement on an issue in the electorate. We would thus expect, for instance, that French

parties would be more responsive to the electorate in the current political climate – in which, 45 per cent of voters said that the European Union threatens French identity (Sondage Le Figaro-LCI-OpinionWay 2014) – by offering a clear position regarding the place of France in the EU.

The current literature on party responsiveness has focused on two primary areas. First, scholars have examined how changes of voter preferences have influenced parties' *left-right positions* (e.g., Adams et al. 2004, 2006, 2009; Ezrow & Hellwig 2014). Although this research has considerably advanced our understanding of how parties' interact with voters, it has not addressed how parties respond to the *issue priorities* of voters. A second, related area of research has thus sought to understand how voters' issue priorities affect government policy (see, e.g., Jones & Baumgartner 2004; Hobolt & Klemmensen 2008; Jennings & John 2009; Jones et al. 2009; Bevan & Jennings 2014). Until recently, however, the responsiveness of political parties to the issue priorities of voters has only received little attention (but see the work by McDonald et al. (2004) and Pennings (2005) on issue priorities and party platforms). A handful of recent studies have begun to shed light on this question by demonstrating that parties do respond to the issue priorities of the electorate, but that party responsiveness is conditioned by the electoral context (Spoon & Klüver 2014), by party type (Klüver & Spoon 2014) and by party organisational structures (Wagner & Meyer 2014). In this article, we build on this emerging research to further understand the relationship between parties and voters by exploring how *voter preferences* condition the influence of *voter priorities* on party responsiveness. In other words, when issues are salient to voters, do parties respond to unified or divided electorates?

To understand the relationship between parties and voters and how it differs across issues, we examine parties' responsiveness in their election manifestos to voters' issue priorities and preferences from 1982 to 2013 in nine European countries. More specifically, we analyse the responsiveness of 69 parties to voters in 31 national elections on two policy issues: immigration and European integration. We consider political parties to be responsive to their voters if an increase in attention to a given policy issue by voters leads to an increase in the attention that parties pay to that policy issue. We measure party issue attention using data from the Comparative Manifestos Project (CMP). Issue priorities of voters are measured using data on the most important issue/problem and voter preferences on immigration and European integration, obtained using positional questions included in the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems and various national election studies, which are listed in the Appendix. Given that a number of scholars have shown that election manifestos are not only a rhetorical exercise, but that parties actually enact the promises they have made in election manifestos during the legislative term (e.g., Thomson 2001; Naurin 2011), our study has important implications not only for party competition, but also for the linkage between voters, parties and governments more generally.

Our findings have important implications for understanding the nature of political representation across parties in Europe. We show that parties indeed respond to the issue priorities of voters, but that the responsiveness of political parties varies with the political context. While one would intuitively expect that parties will run from controversy and converge on the median voter (e.g., Downs 1957), we find that when voters are more divided on an issue, parties are more responsive. Hence, instead of avoiding policy issues on which their party supporters are divided, as conventionally argued (see, e.g., Rovny 2012,

2013), our study shows that political parties pay particular attention to issues that are polarised among the electorate. In sum, political parties do listen to voters, especially when they are divided on a salient issue, thus demonstrating how polarisation can have positive implications for democratic representation.

Party responsiveness and issue polarisation

Issue responsiveness of political parties

As rational, goal-oriented actors, political parties are motivated to maximise their votes (Downs 1957). For some parties, this desire is driven by a commitment to policy (De Swaan 1973), while for others it is driven by a commitment to winning office (Riker 1962). Hence, political parties instrumentally seek to win elections to enact policies, obtain political offices or to enjoy the benefits of both. Importantly, these goals are not necessarily independent of each other and, depending upon the election, parties may be more motivated by one or the other (Strøm 1990; Strøm & Müller 1999). Regardless of the party's underlying motivation, the end result is the same.

To achieve their policy or office goals, parties must attract as many voters as possible. To do this, we posit that political parties primarily compete with each other by selectively emphasising policy issues (Budge & Farlie 1983; Petrocik 1996). Building on the riding-the-wave theory (Ansolabehere & Iyengar 1994), we expect that in order to win elections, parties will focus on the issues that voters emphasise. When parties do not respond to voters, they can appear to be out of touch and not focused on the concerns of the electorate (Sides 2007: 467). This strategy is attractive to parties, as changing policy positions is often difficult because of ideological commitment or reputation (see, e.g., Robertson 1976; Kollman et al. 1992). Indeed, when candidates or parties switch their positions too frequently, they can be accused of political opportunism or 'flip-flopping', which can have negative electoral consequences (Burden 2004; Tavits 2007). Recent research has shown that parties do respond to voter issue attention by highlighting policy issues in their manifestos that are important to voters (Spoon & Klüver 2014; Klüver & Spoon 2014; Wagner & Meyer 2014).

Importantly, parties need time to make their decisions. Just as voters are often retrospective (Fiorina 1981; Kiewiet & Rivers 1984; Powell & Whitten 1993), we argue that parties also act retrospectively. When voters change their issue priorities, political parties need time to process these changes and have to adjust their party manifestos accordingly. Drafting electoral manifestos takes time as there are many actors involved which have to coordinate, and most importantly, have to come to an agreement on the policy priorities and the positions that parties want to convey (see, e.g., Däubler 2012). We thus argue that there is a lagged effect of voter issue attention on the emphasis that parties place on different policy issues in their election manifestos as parties require time to process changes in voters' issue priorities. Similar to Adams and Somer-Topcu (2009), who show that parties gain votes in the current election when they have moderated their positions in the previous election, we posit that parties need time to consider voters' demands and therefore will respond in the subsequent election. Our first hypothesis thus follows from this

understanding of party responsiveness and argues that political parties respond to the issue priorities of voters.

H1: The higher the attention voters paid to a policy issue in the previous election, the higher the attention parties pay to the issue in the current election.

Issue polarisation and its consequences

We have thus far argued that political parties respond to voters by selectively highlighting policy issues that are important to their electorate. However, we expect that party responsiveness is not constant across all policy issues, but that it varies with the preference configuration of voters. For some issues, voters may be unified in their position, while for others, they may be more divided. We argue that the polarisation of the electorate has significant consequences for whether parties respond to voters. More specifically, we expect polarisation to have a positive effect on party responsiveness as parties respond more to voters on divided than on consensual issues.

Scholars have argued that elite polarisation can have negative consequences, including policy gridlock and inaction, a decline in civility in politics and increasing political advertisements that attack opponents among elites (e.g., Jones 2001; Jamieson & Falk 2000; Sinclair 2002; Binder 2003). Similarly, polarisation of political elites can cause a decline in citizen trust in government and result in low levels of political participation among voters (e.g., Shea 2003; Fiorina et al. 2005). Other research, however, has found that the polarisation of political elites that goes hand in hand with more electoral choices can have the opposite effect by exciting and energising voters about the political process, which can result in increased participation (e.g., Hetherington 2007; Abramowitz & Saunders 2008; Dalton 2008; Abramowitz 2010). This follows Downs' (1957) logic that the rate of abstention will increase the closer parties are to each other on the ideological spectrum. In addition, scholars have demonstrated that party polarisation increases cabinet duration (Maoz & Somer-Topcu 2010) and the level of democracy in a country (Wang 2014).

Moreover, when parties are divided on an issue, their positions become clearer and voters are able to make real policy-oriented choices (Carmines & Stimson 1989; Layman et al. 2006). As part of the political context, party polarisation can also influence electoral outcomes. Dalton (2011), for example, demonstrates that voters use left-right ideological orientations in particular to make electoral choices when the party system is polarised. Through experiments, Levendusky (2010) has shown that there is evidence that elite polarisation results in voters that are more consistent in their policy views. They are able to select a party that is more closely aligned with their issue preferences.

Following the literature on elite polarisation, we argue that mass polarisation can have similar effects on party behaviour. When voters have diverging policy preferences, parties will respond by highlighting their differences to attract voters who care about the issues. The underlying reason for this increased party responsiveness is as follows: When policy issues are polarised, voters have clear and pronounced policy positions on these issues and behave in line with their policy views (Levendusky 2010). In situations of heightened polarisation, voters base their vote choices on the proximity of their preferences to those of political parties (Dalton 2011). Thus, while other factors such as candidate popularity or

party identification play a crucial role for voters' decisions on the ballot on consensual issues, policy distances between voters and political parties become a much more important determinant of vote choice on highly conflictual issues. Accordingly, in the American context, scholars have found an inverse relationship between mass polarisation and ticket-splitting. As partisanship has increased, the percentage of voters splitting their vote between presidential and congressional candidates has decreased, thus highlighting the connection between mass polarisation and party preference (Hetherington 2001; Jacobson 2005; Abramowitz 2010). When voters are divided on an issue and parties offer clear alternatives, they will throw their support behind the party that is most closely aligned with their preferences.

How does voter polarisation affect the responsiveness of parties to voters' issue attention? Following the findings of the polarisation literature, we expect that parties will devote considerably more attention to polarised issues in their election manifestos to clearly spell out their issue-specific positions, to unambiguously transmit their policy preferences to voters and to distinguish themselves from competitors. As voters make their vote choice on polarised issues on the basis of the ideological stances that parties have on these issues, parties will be particularly responsive to voters' issue salience if an issue divides the electorate. They will discuss polarised issues at length in their manifestos to clearly convey their policy positions on these conflictual issues and to ensure that voters are aware of their stances on these issues. With regard to party responsiveness to voters' issue priorities, we thus hypothesise that political parties are more responsive to voter issue attention on highly polarised issues. For example, if the electorate is divided on a highly salient issue, such as whether to end the use of nuclear energy, then parties are more likely to respond by devoting a great deal of attention to the issue in their manifestos to clearly communicate their policy stances on the issue to voters. Our second, and central, hypothesis follows from this expectation and focuses on the interaction of voter salience and voter polarisation.

H2: Parties respond more in the current election to voters' issue attention on policy issues that are polarised among voters in the previous election.

Research design

Measuring party issue responsiveness

To examine the responsiveness of political parties to the issue priorities and preferences of voters, we look at how the attention that voters pay to different issues in the previous election, which we denote as t_{-1} , combined with their preferences, influences the policy issues that parties emphasise in the current election, which we denote as t_0 . To measure the issue responsiveness of political parties, we include a time lag between the issue priorities and preferences of voters and the parties' issue attention assuming that political parties need some time to process changes in public issue salience and voter preferences to adjust their issue priorities, as discussed above.

We measure the issue attention of political parties by the emphasis that they place on different policy issues in their election manifestos. There are, however, alternative

approaches to measuring the salience of issues for political parties of which expert surveys are the most prominent (e.g., Hooghe et al. 2010). There is a vibrant discussion in the literature about the quality of manifesto and expert surveys for the measurement of parties' issue salience as each approach is associated with certain advantages and disadvantages (see, e.g., Mikhaylov et al. 2012). We have decided to use manifesto data for the following reasons. First, election manifestos have a specific number of words that parties can use to express their stance on different policy issues. When drafting their election manifesto, parties have to decide how much attention they place on different issues – that is, how many sentences they will allocate to different policy domains. Manifestos are thus an ideal data source to measure parties' issue salience as political parties signal to voters that a certain policy issue will be prioritised by laying out their ideas for this issue area in great detail. Second, while expert surveys are only available for a limited number of time points, manifestos are drafted by all major political parties for every single election so that we can study party responsiveness drawing on a comprehensive time-series cross-section analysis.

We rely on information extracted from election manifestos by the Comparative Manifesto Project (Volkens et al. 2013). Human coders have divided the election manifestos into units of analysis (so-called 'quasi-sentences') and then allocated these quasi-sentences to policy categories specified a priori in a coding scheme. The attention that political parties pay to policy issues is measured by taking the percentage of quasi-sentences devoted to a certain issue area. The issue areas, however, do not reflect positions; in other words, they include both positive and negative mentions of the issue. Thus, the multiculturalism category includes both support and opposition to multiculturalism. We combine these issue dimensions as we are interested in measuring how salient an issue is for a party and not necessarily the position it has taken. Our dependent variable is thus the party's attention to an issue area in a specific election. This is measured by summing the percentage of positive and negative mentions of an issue area in the party's manifesto.

Assessing voter priorities and preferences

To measure how voter polarisation conditions the influence that voter attention has on party issue attention, we use two sets of information. First, to measure the attention that voters pay to different policy issues we rely on the so-called 'most important problem/issue' (MIP) question included in a number of different national and cross-national surveys.¹ This question asks respondents to indicate the most important problem/issue that their country is currently facing. This question is a standard tool for measuring issue priorities of voters that has been used by a wide variety of scholars in comparative politics (e.g., Hobolt & Klemmensen 2008; Jennings & John 2009). Second, to measure the polarisation of the electorate on an issue, we use responses to survey questions that ask voters about their policy positions on various issues (see also, e.g., De Vries 2007). For a given question, we use the standard deviation of the mean voter response to determine the electorate's position on an issue (see also Ezrow et al. 2014). To assess party responsiveness, we thus measure the attention that parties pay to different policy issues in the current election, t_0 , while measuring the issue priorities and preferences of voters at t_1 , the previous national election.²

To empirically test our hypotheses, we analyse party responsiveness in two issue areas in nine European democracies for which we were able to find comparable data for both: issue attention and issue positions in public opinion surveys. The countries included in our analysis are Denmark, Finland, Germany, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Portugal, Sweden and the United Kingdom. We selected these countries as we were able to find open-ended MIP questions as well as comparable issue position questions across these states for which there are corresponding CMP categories for two issues: European integration and immigration.³ To create the party's attention to a policy issue, we summed the negative mentions and the positive mentions for each issue category. For the EU issue category, we used *per108* (EC/EU-positive) and *per110* (EC/EU-negative) and for the immigration issue category we used *per601* (national way of life-positive), *per602* (national way of life-negative), *per607* (multiculturalism-positive) and *per608* (multiculturalism-negative) (Volkens et al. 2013).

We only include elections for which we have a comparable MIP question and position question from the previous election survey. As the position questions had different scales, we followed the re-scaling strategy developed by Preston and Colman (2000) and Dawes (2008) to re-scale each question to a 0–10 scale, with 0 representing the pro-immigration/European integration position and 10 representing the anti-immigration/European integration position to make each question comparable.⁴ Importantly, the correlation between voter issue attention and voter issue polarisation is relatively low ($r = 0.25$). Hence, policy issues can be polarised without being salient to the voters and vice versa. As the MIP questions are open-ended, we coded responses into policy areas and used the percentage of respondents who indicated that immigration or European integration is the most important policy issue that their country is currently facing.

Our data comes from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems and from various additional national election studies.⁵ See the Appendix for a list of election studies used for the MIP and issue position data. In all, we examine the issue responsiveness of 69 parties in 31 national elections from 1982 to 2013.

Control variables

We also include several party- and party-system-level control variables as these may condition party responsiveness. First, we include a variable for *party size*, which is measured as the vote share of the party in the previous national election. Second, we include a variable for *governing party status*. A party is considered a governing party if it was in government at the time of the election under consideration. The data on party size was obtained from the CMP dataset and the government participation data comes from the ParlGov dataset (Döring & Manow 2012). Third, we code parties as *niche* or *mainstream* parties. We use Meguid's (2005) definition of 'niche party' and code green, regional and far right parties as such. Based on previous research, we expect larger parties to be more responsive, governing parties to be less responsive, and niche parties generally to be no more responsive than mainstream parties to voters (Klüver & Spoon 2014). Fourth, we control for *average district magnitude*. We argue that the larger the magnitude, the less responsive parties will be as they do not need to appeal to as many voters to be elected. We draw these data from Golder (2006) and add the data after 2000. Fifth, we control for the distance in *days between the*

current and previous election. We argue that the closer the previous election is, the more responsive parties will be to voters' issue priorities and preferences. Finally, we control for the *left-right position* of political parties as party responsiveness may vary with the overall ideological stance of parties. We measured the ideal points of parties on the left-right continuum using the proportional scale suggested by Budge (1999) by subtracting the percentage of left quasi-sentences from the percentage of right quasi-sentences coded by the CMP (see Appendix Table 1 for descriptive statistics for all variables included in the empirical analysis).⁶

Data analysis

To investigate how polarisation affects party responsiveness, the particular structure of the dataset has to be considered. We analyse the responsiveness of 69 parties to voters in 31 national elections regarding two policy issues: immigration and European integration. The observations in our dataset are therefore not independent of each other, but hierarchically clustered into policy issues, on the one hand, and nested into political parties, on the other. In order to acknowledge the clustering of the data, we estimate ordinary least squares (OLS) regression models with clustered robust standard errors. More specifically, we created a clustering variable that takes on different values for the various combinations of policy issues and parties, and, based on these, we estimated the clustered robust standard errors (e.g., SPD – European integration (1), SPD – Immigration (2), FDP – European integration (3), FDP – Immigration (4)).⁷ Since we also analyse succeeding elections in the nine countries in our sample, the observations in our dataset are also dependent over time. To control for potential autocorrelation induced by the time-series structure of the data, we include the lagged dependent variable (Beck & Katz 1995; Beck 2001).⁸

Table 1 presents the results of the OLS regression analyses testing *H1*, which argued that parties emphasise policy issues in their manifestos that are important to their electorate.⁹ Model 1 indicates a statistically significant positive effect of voter issue attention at t_{-1} on party issue salience at t_0 . Hence, political parties are responsive to the issue priorities of the entire electorate. This result follows the findings of Spoon and Klüver (2014), Klüver and Spoon (2014), and Wagner and Meyer (2014).

In our central hypothesis, we argue that the extent of party issue responsiveness varies with the degree of polarisation of policy issues among voters. To shed light on the effect of polarisation at the voter level, we first present descriptive information about the extent to which voters disagree over these two issues. Figure 1 plots the mean positions of all voters in a given election on both the European integration and the immigration dimension. As explained in the previous section, the policy positions of voters are measured on a 0–10 scale, where 0 indicates a positive position and 10 indicates a negative position on the respective issue. Figure 1 demonstrates that there is considerable polarisation among voters on both dimensions. The mean voter position on the EU dimension ranges from 3.75 to 5.25. On the immigration dimension, the mean voter position ranges from 4.08 to 7.15. Thus, there is considerable polarisation across countries and elections among voters on both policy dimensions. However, disagreement is on average larger on the immigration than on the European integration dimension.

Table 1. Examining party issue responsiveness to voters

DV: Party issue attention t_0	Model 1
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	0.046* (0.023)
Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	0.359 (0.414)
Party size	-0.017 (0.012)
Government status	0.239 (0.335)
Niche party	0.335 (0.648)
Average district magnitude	-0.002 (0.002)
Number of days between current and past election	-0.000 (0.000)
Left-right position of party	0.023** (0.009)
Party issue attention t_{-1}	0.672*** (0.046)
Constant	0.198 (1.343)
N	308
R ²	0.59

Notes: *** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.10$. Results are from an ordinary least squares regression with clustered robust standard errors.

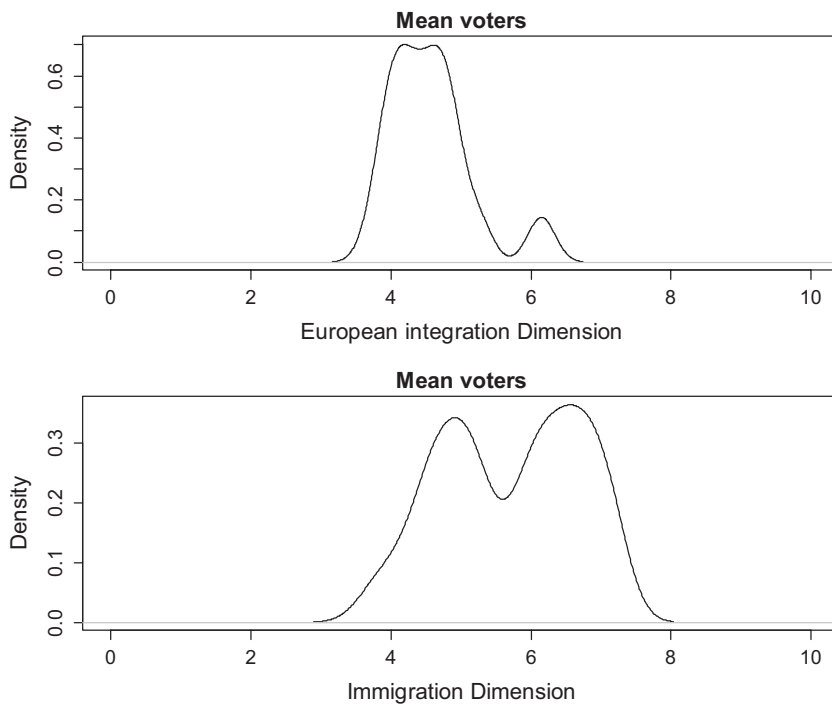


Figure 1. Voter positions on European integration and immigration.

Table 2. Examining the conditioning effect of polarisation

DV: Party issue attention t_0	Model 2	Model 3
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	-0.489*** (0.161)	-0.606** (0.266)
Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	-0.671 (0.460)	-0.771 (0.507)
Party size	-0.013 (0.012)	-0.025* (0.014)
Government status	0.222 (0.338)	0.692** (0.296)
Niche party	0.546 (0.658)	0.093 (0.512)
Average district magnitude	0.001 (0.002)	0.003 (0.002)
Number of days between current and past election	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.000 (0.000)
Left-right position of party	0.026*** (0.009)	0.013* (0.007)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	0.168*** (0.055)	0.197*** (0.071)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Party size		0.003 (0.002)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Government status		-0.098 (0.070)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Niche party		0.080 (0.063)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Average district magnitude		-0.000 (0.000)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Number of days between current and past election		0.000 (0.000)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Left-right position of party		0.003** (0.001)
Party issue attention t_{-1}	0.626*** (0.049)	0.556*** (0.060)
Constant	2.701* (1.465)	3.406** (1.559)
N	308	308
R ²	0.60	0.62

Notes: *** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.10$. Results are from an ordinary least squares regression with clustered robust standard errors.

Importantly, when we examine issue polarisation across all of the countries in our dataset, we find that for both the EU and immigration dimensions the mean standard deviation for both issues for voters is slightly above 3.0. These polarisation values represent roughly the midpoint on the spectrum (see Appendix). The results thus demonstrate that these two issues are not necessarily more polarising than other issues and show, on average, continuing support for European integration across Europe despite increasing euroscepticism in some countries (Hooghe & Marks 2009).

In order to test $H2$, which posited that party responsiveness varies with the extent of issue polarisation among voters, we have included an interaction effect between lagged voter issue attention and lagged voter issue polarisation. The results are reported in Table 2. Model 2 includes interaction effects only for the main explanatory variables, while model 3 includes interaction effects for all control variables as they may also have a conditional effect on party issue attention. Both model specifications indicate that there is a statistically significant positive interaction effect at play between voter issue attention and the polarisation of the issue among voters. This interaction effect indicates that party responsiveness systematically increases as the mass polarisation of an issue rises. Hence, the larger the polarisation of an issue among the entire electorate, the larger the responsiveness of parties to the issue priorities of voters. Parties respond to the policy priorities of voters, but parties

listen more to the electorate if policy issues are highly polarised. To examine whether the conditioning effect of voter polarisation might differ across policy issues, we have estimated a model that includes a fixed effect for policy issue area as a robustness check (see Appendix Table 2). The findings essentially correspond to what we report in Table 2: polarisation has a constant effect on party responsiveness across both policy issues.

One may wonder what the sources of mass polarisation are. In particular, one may argue that mass polarisation is endogenous to party competition as political parties may cause polarisation among voters (see, e.g., Adams et al. 2004, 2009), Bélanger & Meguid (2008) for a discussion of how voters respond to parties' issue emphasis and De Vries (2007) on how parties can influence the saliency of the EU for voters). To shed light on the interaction between parties and voters with regard to polarisation, we have conducted a Granger causality test reported in Appendix Table 3. The test indicates that parties cause voter polarisation, but that voter polarisation does not lead to party polarisation on an issue. While this is an important finding that deserves further attention, investigating the sources of polarisation in more detail goes beyond the scope of this particular article.¹⁰ While this study has shown that voter polarisation on an issue leads to higher party responsiveness on that issue, future research should shed further light on why issues become polarised among voters in the first place and what role political parties play in that regard.

Turning to the control variables, we find a systematic effect for the left-right position of parties, which indicates that parties located on the right side of the political spectrum pay, on average, more attention to the European integration and the immigration issue in their manifestos (see model 2). Moreover, we also find that right-wing parties respond more strongly to voters' issue priorities than left-wing parties (see model 3). This finding is similar to that of Adams et al. (2009), who argue that right-wing parties are more responsive than left-wing parties to both shifts in public opinion and global economic conditions.

To further illustrate how party responsiveness varies with the polarisation of an issue, Figure 2 shows the marginal effect of voter issue attention at t_{-1} on party issue attention at t_0 as the polarisation of an issue among voters varies. The figure clearly demonstrates that the issue responsiveness of parties increases as the polarisation of an issue among voters rises. Figure 2 also demonstrates that party responsiveness not only increases with the polarisation of policy issues, but that the marginal effect of voter issue attention at t_{-1} on party issue attention at t_0 is in fact negative for highly consensual issues. Hence, political parties pay less attention to policy issues than voters if the electorate largely agrees on these issues.

To illustrate our findings on the conditioning effect of polarisation, we can examine the issue responsiveness of three parties in our dataset. In 2001, 40.0 per cent of the *Dansk Folkeparti*'s (Danish People's Party) manifesto focused on immigration. In the previous election, the Danish electorate both cared about the issue and was considerably divided over it: 15.8 per cent responded that immigration was the most important issue and the standard deviation of the electorate's position on immigration was 3.88. Conversely, only 2.85 per cent of the *Dutch Partij van de Arbeid*'s (Labour Party-PvDA) 2010 manifesto focused on immigration. Although voters cared a lot about this issue (saliency = 21.1 per cent), the level of voter polarisation was very low (standard deviation of the electorate = 2.68). Similarly, when an issue is neither important nor polarising, parties also do not respond. For instance, in 2007, *Fianna Fáil* devoted only 1.12 per cent of its manifesto to

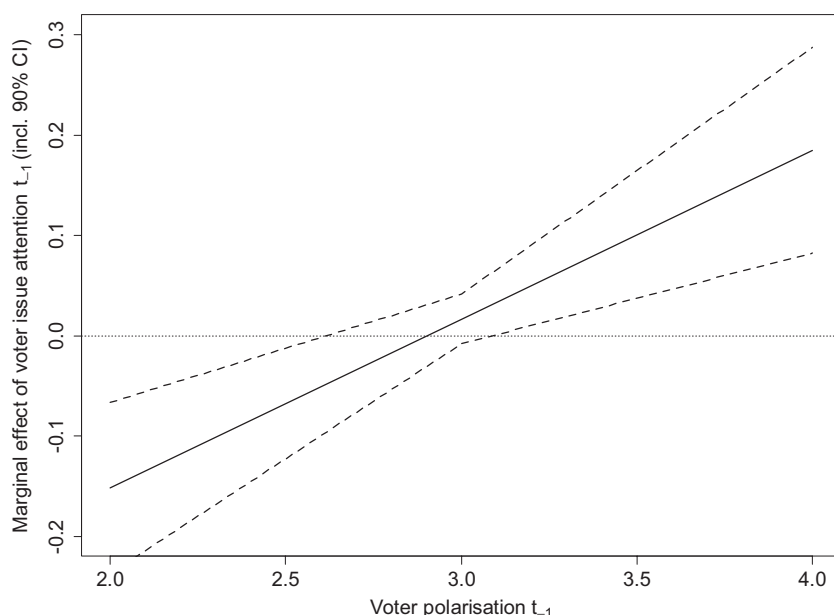


Figure 2. The conditioning effect of polarisation.

Notes: The figure is based on model 2 reported in Table 2. The dashed lines are the 90 per cent confidence intervals.

European integration as Irish voters were neither focused upon nor divided over the issue in the previous election (salience = 3.84; standard deviation of the electorate = 2.66).

Conclusion

Do parties downplay polarised issues in order not to disappoint parts of the electorate or do they instead pay particular attention to issues that divide the electorate to clearly spell out their policy stance? To answer this question, we have analysed the effect of voter polarisation on the issue responsiveness of political parties. We have argued that political parties are particularly responsive to policy priorities of voters if policy issues are highly polarised. As voters have more sincere policy preferences on polarised issues, and since they base their vote choice on the proximity to political parties' policy preferences in a highly politicised climate, we posited that political parties pay considerable attention to these issues to clearly convey their policy positions to voters. Based on a comparative analysis of 69 parties competing in 31 national elections in nine Western European countries, we have shown that the issue responsiveness of political parties indeed increases with the polarisation of the immigration and European integration issues among voters.

Our findings have important implications for party competition and political representation. We have demonstrated that the extent to which political parties respond to the policy priorities of citizens depends on the degree of voter polarisation on political issues. Hence, contrary to what one may intuitively expect, political parties do not downplay issues on

which voters are divided (see, e.g., Rovny 2012, 2013), but they instead devote much more of their manifesto to polarised issues to clearly signal their positions to voters. Our study thus extends previous research on party competition that has essentially treated policy issues equally by showing that parties respond to voter preferences and voter attention in a similar way across issues. However, in line with our findings, it is important to acknowledge that party responsiveness varies across policy issues depending on the level of voter polarisation. Thus, to better understand party competition, it is imperative to take into account the issue context.

With regard to political representation, this article sheds new light on the role of polarisation in democratic societies. Previous research has pointed to the negative consequences of polarisation for the functioning of modern democracies. For instance, Lijphart (1999) as well as Powell (1982) have argued that highly polarised party systems lead to higher levels of political conflict and citizen protest. By contrast, another strand of research has shown that polarisation can have positive effects for political representation in democracies (e.g., Abramowitz 2010; Abramowitz & Saunders 2008; Hetherington 2007; Dalton 2008). According to the responsible party model (APSA 1950), parties should offer voters clear policy alternatives from which to make their choice. Following this line of reasoning, polarisation enhances political representation as voters can select parties that closely resemble their policy views (Dalton 2011). Our study adds to the latter view by demonstrating that polarisation at the voter level also has positive implications for political representation. Polarisation makes parties more responsive to voters. Parties listen more to the policy concerns of citizens if they are divided on an issue. When voters strongly disagree on an issue, political parties take their views seriously and pay a lot of attention to these issues by clearly highlighting their positions and by distinguishing themselves from their competitors. Hence, instead of undermining political representation and democratic linkage, polarisation in fact strengthens the link between political parties and their voters, which is one of the central functions of parties in democracies (Lawson 1980, 2005; Dalton et al. 2011).

Although we have added to our understanding of the relationship between voters and parties, there are still several questions remaining unanswered that should be addressed in future research. First, scholars should examine the sources of polarisation. We have explored how voter polarisation influences the issue attention of parties, but how do policy issues become polarised in the first place? We have discussed preliminary evidence that indicates that political parties cause polarisation at the mass level; however, this finding deserves further exploration. In particular, future research should analyse how the strategies of individual parties lead to an increase or a decrease of the polarisation of an issue among voters drawing on individual-level panel data. Second, how parties shift their own issue positions in response to voters' issue positions in both unified and divided contexts is an important extension of our work on issue attention. Finally, as we were interested in examining responsiveness across countries, we were limited to two issue areas because of the survey questions that were asked. These two issues have been very prominent in recent years so studying how polarisation conditions party responsiveness on both of these issues highlights challenges for party competition. However, in order to generalise the findings beyond these two issues, researchers might consider sacrificing some of the cross-national component to examine additional issue areas in a smaller sub-set of countries.

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Appendix

Appendix Table 1. Descriptive statistics

	N	Mean	Standard deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Party issue attention t_0	318	2.860	4.287	0.000	40.000
Party issue attention t_{-1}	318	3.148	4.363	0.000	40.000
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	318	5.463	7.526	0.000	29.080
Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	318	3.072	0.451	2.450	3.950
Party size	318	14.463	11.811	0.000	46.396
Government status	318	0.283	0.451	0.000	1.000
Niche party	318	0.167	0.373	0.000	1.000
Average district magnitude	318	38.803	58.873	0.000	150.000
Number of days since last election	318	1316.597	365.543	252.000	2526.000
Left-right position of party	318	-2.296	21.380	-45.418	59.800

Appendix Table 2. Examining the conditioning effect of polarisation across policy issues

DV: Party issue attention t_0	Model 4
Voter issue attention t_{-1}	-0.493*** (0.160)
Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	-0.624 (0.475)
Voter issue attention t_{-1} * Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	0.165*** (0.055)
Party size	-0.013 (0.012)
Government status	0.229 (0.340)
Niche party	0.513 (0.649)
Average district magnitude	0.002 (0.002)
Number of days between current and past election	-0.000 (0.000)
Left-right position of party	0.024** (0.009)
Issue: European integration	0.574* (0.310)
Party issue attention t_{-1}	0.643*** (0.052)
Constant	1.553 (1.880)
N	308
R ²	0.60

Notes: *** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$; * $p < 0.10$. Results are from an ordinary least squares regression with clustered robust standard errors. The reference category for the dummy variable 'Issue: European integration' is the immigration issue.

Appendix Table 3. Granger causality test concerning polarisation

Exogenous variable	Restricted coefficients	F statistic	p-value
Voter issue polarisation t_{-1}	Party issue polarisation t_0	27.82	0.00
Party issue polarisation t_{-1}	Voter issue polarisation t_0	1.28	0.26

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Notes

1. We acknowledge that ‘most important issue’ and ‘most important problem’ are not necessarily the same question (see Wlezien (2005) and Jennings & Wlezien (2011) for a more recent discussion of how there is little difference between the two questions) and that MIP questions do not always accurately represent the public’s preferences (see Jennings & Wlezien 2012). However, as these are the best cross-national questions available to gauge policy priorities of citizens, we use both ‘most important issue’ and ‘most important problem’ questions in order to have as much of a cross-national time-series as possible (see Jennings & John 2009: 844).
2. We have estimated an additional model specification in which we measure the issue priorities and preferences of voters in the same national election as the issue attention of parties (both are measured at t_0). The results are essentially the same regardless of whether we use the lagged or the concurrent priorities and preferences of voters.
3. Ideally, we would have liked to test our hypotheses on a larger selection of issues; however, given that we were constrained by issues that were covered in both election surveys and the CMP dataset, we are limited to these two issues. As we highlight below, these two issues are, however, not necessarily more polarising than other issues. Moreover, although the two issues are related, the correlation between them at the voter level is 0.47 and 0.45 at the party level.
4. To check whether the different scales used in the various surveys affect our results, we have estimated a robustness check by including a measure for the number of answer categories used for the different survey questions in the regression analyses. The results are nearly identical and we thus only present the models without this scale measure.
5. We only use MIP data from national election studies and do not rely on polling data to generate a comparable dataset across countries.
6. As some values for voter issue attention seem particularly high, we checked the robustness of the findings by conducting our empirical analyses without outliers. The results are substantially the same as in the complete analysis presented in the next section.
7. Since the results may also systematically vary across countries, we have run additional robustness checks including fixed effects for countries in all the regression models we present. However, the results are substantially the same and we therefore only present the most parsimonious model, which accounts for the clustering into parties and policy issue areas.
8. Importantly, parties’ issue emphasis is not only influenced by voters’ issue priorities and preferences, but also by those of other parties in the system. The lagged dependent variable thus also serves as a proxy measure for the salience of the issue in the party system at t_0 . The correlation between the two variables is 0.63. Since including the lagged dependent variable might consume a large extent of the

variation, we have also estimated the models without the lagged dependent variable. As the results for the conditioning effect of polarisation are substantially the same (the effect is simply larger), we only present the full model, which includes the lagged dependent variable.

9. Following recent literature that posits that parties may respond differently to the preferences of voters and party supporters (see, e.g., Adams et al. 2006; Hobolt & Klemmensen 2008; Ezrow et al. 2011), we also ran our analyses only looking at responsiveness to party supporters. While we found that parties respond to the issue priorities of party supporters, the effect was not statistically significant at conventional levels. We, however, do find statistically significant evidence that parties respond to both voters and party supporters when issue attention and polarisation are high. Parties may emphasise issues on which their supporters are divided as these are the issues on which their supporters are the most engaged and have the most potential to be mobilised. This is highlighting the same finding that we found in the overall electorate – that counter to expectations, parties respond more to divided electorates/supporters when salience is high. Political parties devote particular attention to polarised issues when these are salient to clearly spell out their issue-specific positions, to unambiguously transmit their policy preferences to voters and to distinguish themselves from competitors.
10. It is important to note that the level of polarisation among voters cannot be controlled by one single party as the polarisation of an issue among citizens is affected by the strategies of all political parties in a party system. Since the goal of this study is to investigate the effect of voter polarisation on party issue responsiveness, we thus treat voter polarisation as an exogenous variable.

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